

Session programme

Marking and intercepting to defend



Contents

Week one: marking rivals	3
Week two: defend as friends	5
Week three: interception perfection	7
Week four: table football	9
Week five: intercept as a team	11
Week six: festival week	13

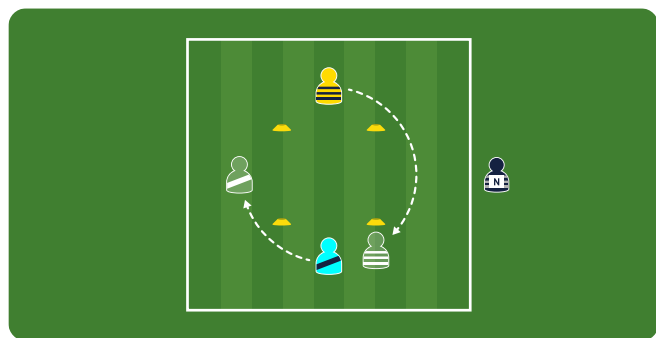
Week one: marking rivals

This session will help players:

- understand what marking is
- become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- use scanning, movement, and positioning skills to mark an opponent or zone.

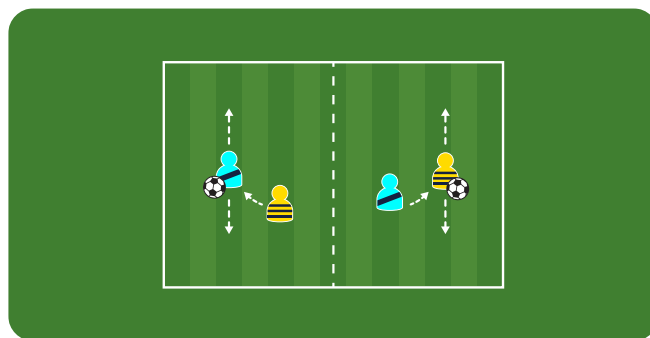
Coaching points

- Focus on really good movement to close the ball down. Encourage players to try to stay close to their opponent to prevent them from receiving the ball easily.
- Encourage players to be goal-side of their opponents to stop them from having an easy route to goal.
- Ask players to think about their body positioning. Being able to see their opponent and the ball at the same time can help with anticipating an opponent's next move. And adopting a side-on stance at the right time can help them steal the ball.



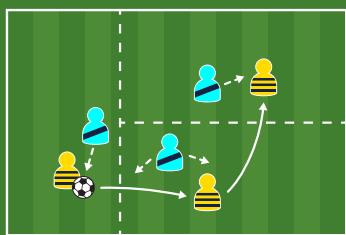
Arrival activity

- For cat and mouse, create a 5x5-yard square.
- Have a 1v1 with players starting opposite each other on the outside of the area.
- Players run around the area. They can't go through it.
- The cat has 15 seconds to tag the mouse.
- Players swap roles after the time limit or if the mouse is caught.



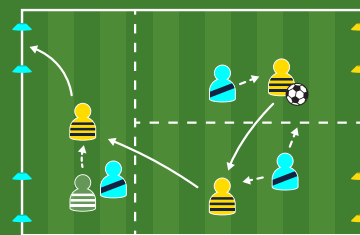
Practice one

- For the stadium game, create a 30x20-yard area with a halfway line.
- Pair players up. Allocate each player to a team and give them a half to act as their stadium. One player in each pair starts with a ball.
- The aim is to have the ball under control in your own stadium after 30 seconds.



Practice two

- Put flat markers down in a 'T' shape to split the stadium game pitch into three areas for 3v3 rivals.
- Have a 1v1 in each area. Players are locked in.
- One team starts with the ball.
- The aim is to keep possession as a team.
- The team off the ball must work together to mark effectively to win it back.



Practice two – progression

- You could progress this game to make it directional by adding end zones, gates or goals.
- Overall, play for five to seven minutes, then have a break before playing another round.

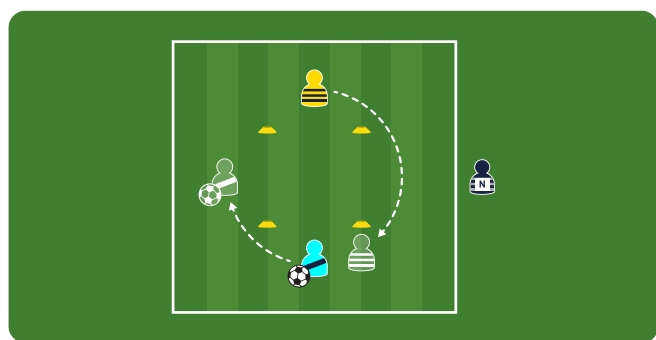
Week two: defend as friends

This session will help players:

- become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- use scanning, movement, and positioning skills to mark an opponent or zone
- communicate with teammates to defend effectively.

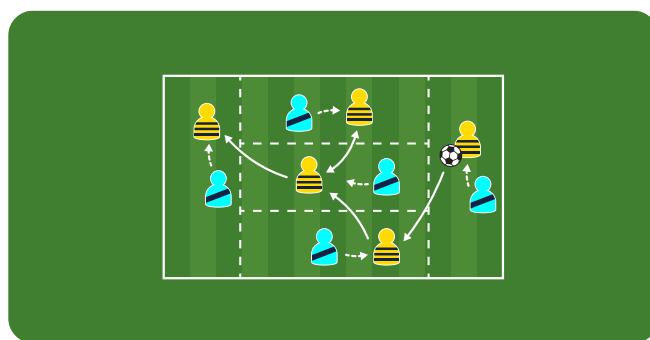
Coaching points

- Encourage players to scan to help them think about where the space may be and where their opponent may go.
- Challenge players to stay close to their opponent, anticipate their moves, and use their body, and quick footwork, to block their path.
- Ask players to communicate with teammates, stay alert, and move quickly to challenge an opponent.



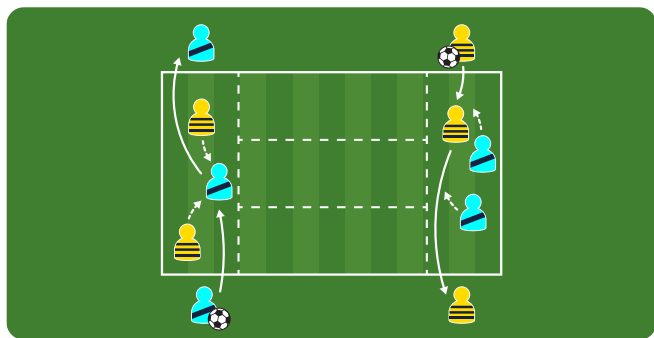
Arrival activity

- For cat and mouse, create a 5x5-yard square.
- Have a 1v1 with players starting opposite each other.
- The mouse carries a football.
- Players run around the area. They can't go through it.
- The cat has 15 seconds to tag the mouse.
- Players swap roles after the time limit or if the mouse is caught.



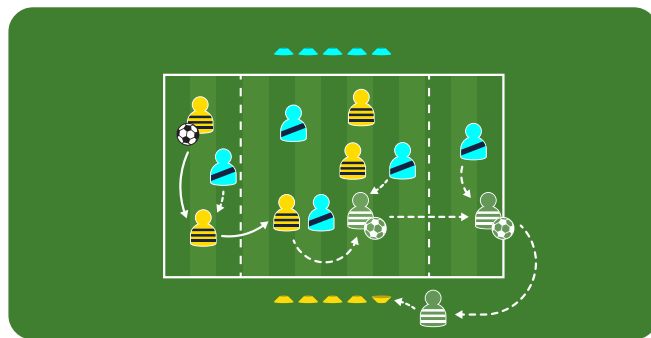
Practice one

- Create a 30x20-yard area and split it into five sections. Have a 1v1 in each. Players are locked in.
- One team starts with the ball. The other side work together to win it back.
- The aim is to keep possession as a team.
- Teams score a point when all their players have had the ball without losing it.



Practice two

- Use the end channels from the last game for this 3v2 practice.
- Have an attacker at both ends of the channel, with one in the middle against two defenders.
- Attackers try to get it from one side to the other.
- Defenders work together mark, cover and intercept to win the ball.



Practice three

- Return to the rivals game but remove the middle channels.
- Put a line of cones down each side of the pitch.
- Teams combine to try to work the ball over the end line to score.
- The scorer then runs off to turn one of their cones over. This then creates an overload for the opposition.

Week three: interception perfection

This session will help players:

- become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- communicate with teammates to defend effectively
- understand the importance of a positive action after they intercept the ball.

Coaching points

- Encourage players to communicate to work together effectively and adjust their positioning.
- Get players to think about 'why' 'when' and 'how' when it comes to intercepting. Closing down at the right time, or staying compact, will minimise the danger of being 'played through' and help them to win the ball.
- When intercepting, challenge players to think about what they need to do before, during and after an interception.

Before

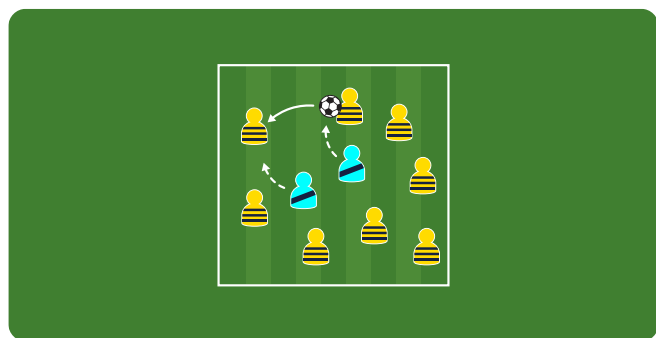
- Try to judge whether an interception is possible.
- Try to make sure you can see the path of the ball and relevant attackers.
- Try to make sure you can see the space you want to use when you win the ball.

During

- Try to be prepared to use different surfaces to make first contact.
- Try to leave attackers behind with your first touch.

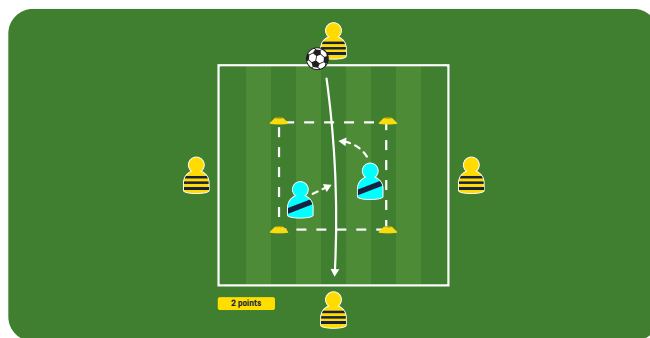
After

- Try to follow up the interception with good positive actions and techniques, for example, a pass, dribble or shot.



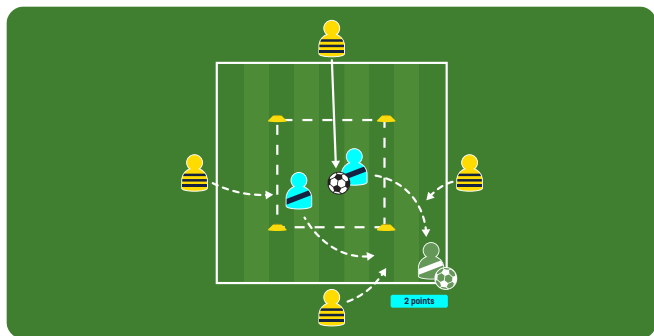
Arrival activity

- Set up a 20x20-yard box for this arrival activity.
- Have two taggers or interceptors.
- The rest have one ball between them and must use their hands to throw and catch. They can't move with the ball.
- The pair have 30 seconds to intercept it.
- They swap roles if they succeed, or the time runs out.



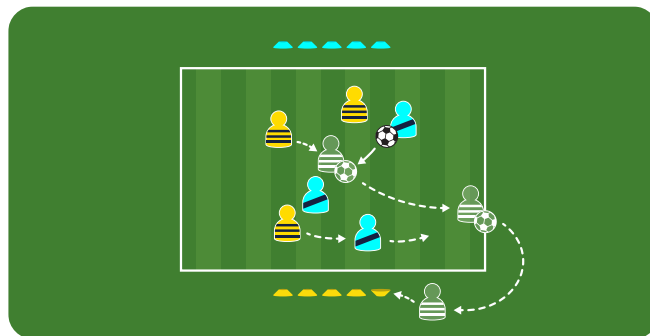
Carousel – practice one

- Create a 20x20-yard box for the first carousel activity. Put a square in the middle of it.
- Have four attackers around the outside of the box, and two defenders inside the middle square.
- Attackers look to play through the square for a point, or through the two defenders for two points.



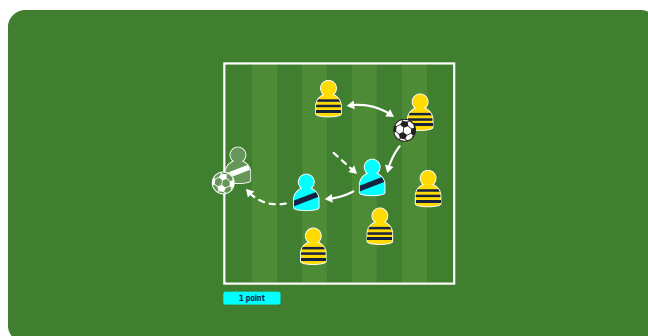
Carousell – practice one continued

- If the defenders manage to get any touch on the ball, they get a point. But if they intercept a pass, they can break out to try to get the ball over the line – or into one of the corners – to score two points.
- Attackers can enter the area to stop them.



Carousell – practice two

- The second carousel activity needs a 30x20-yard area for 3v3 rivals.
- Teams combine and work the ball over the end line to score.
- The out of possession team look to mark, cover and intercept to win the ball, before working it over the line to score.
- Whoever scores runs to turn a cone over.



Carousell practice three

- For the final part of the carousel, use the arrival activity area.
- Here, play a possession-based game, where a group of players look to keep the ball, and two defenders try to win it back.
- If the defenders succeed, they score a point by dribbling out of the area with the ball.

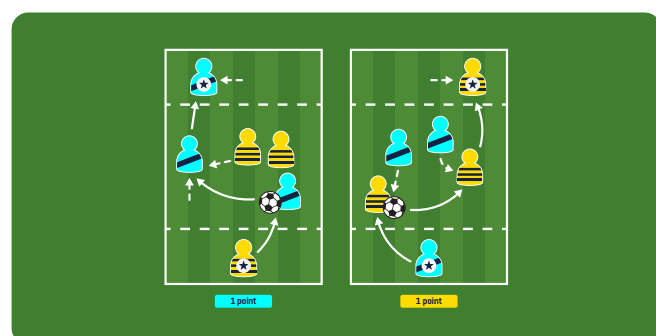
Week four: table football

This session will help players:

- become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- understand what intercepting is
- work on their positioning
- read the game and anticipate where the ball may go.

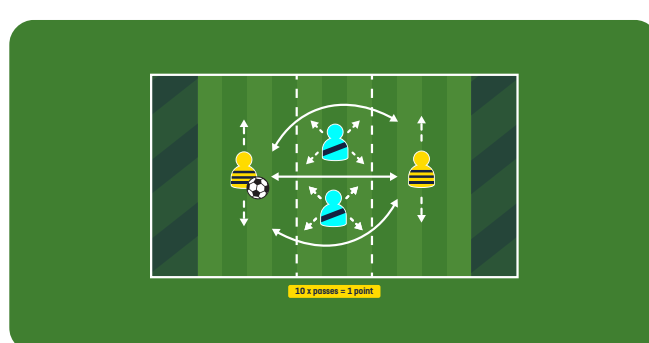
Coaching points

- Encourage players to constantly scan the pitch to be aware of the positions and movements of both their teammates and opponents. This helps them anticipate passes and be ready to intercept.
- Teach players to position themselves between the ball or the player they're marking and the goal. Their body should be oriented in a way that allows them to quickly move towards the ball but also be aware of the goal they're protecting.
- Ask players to think about the timing of their movement. This is vital for intercepting. They need to consider not moving too early to encourage more dangerous passes. But if they move too late, they may not be able to get to the ball.
- Encourage players to look up and assess their options once they've intercepted the ball. Whether it's passing to a teammate, driving forward or even clearing the ball, players need to quickly decide what to do next.



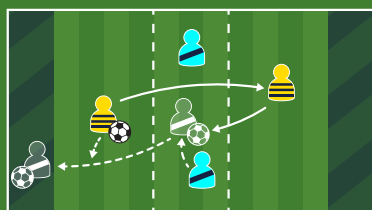
Practice one

- Create parallel 15x10-yard pitches with end zones for 3v3 table football.
- Have a 2v2 in the middle with each team having a target player in their own end zone.
- Teams aim to get the ball to their target player for a point. If this happens, the opposition restart the game with the ball.



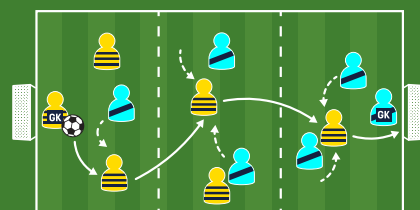
Practice two

- Create a 30x20-yard pitch with end zones at each end and a zone in the middle.
- Two interceptors start in the middle zone.
- A passer starts in each area between the zones.
- Passers aim to pass to each other without the ball being intercepted. They score a point for every ten successful passes.



Practice two – continued

- If an interceptor cuts out a pass they get a point, but they can also break out to create a 1v1.
- If they manage to get to the end zone with the ball, they score two points and the teams swap roles.
- You can also change the teams around so players experience facing others.



Practice three

- Create a pitch that's split into thirds and has a goal and keepers at each end.
- Have two defenders and an attacker in each final third, and a 2v2 in the middle.
- Players are locked into their thirds.
- Teams aim to play through the thirds to create a chance for their attacker to score.

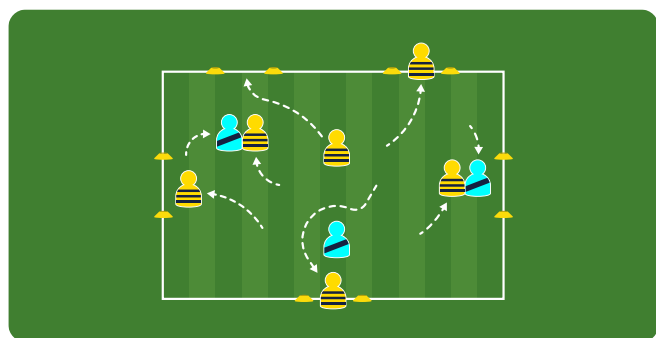
Week five: intercept as a team

This session will help players:

- become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- make informed decisions of when to mark and when to intercept.

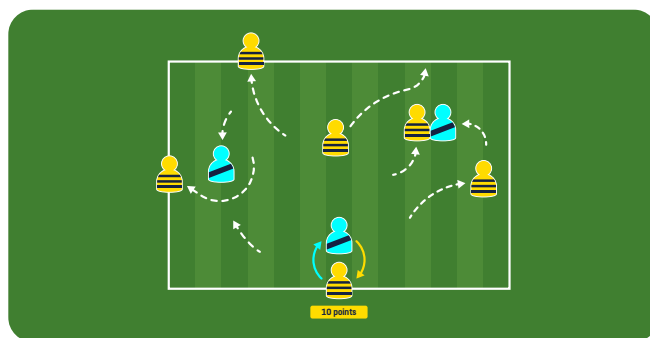
Coaching points

- Remind defenders to position themselves strategically, anticipating the movements of the attackers. They should stay on their toes, ready to react quickly to any changing situations.
- Encourage players to react positively when they make an interception by launching a counter-attack if possible.



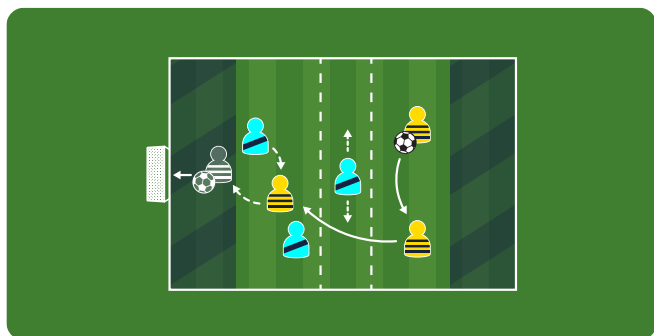
Arrival activity

- For the escape game, create a 30x20-yard area with multiple gates around the edge of it.
- Have a few defenders with the rest being attackers.
- The defenders need to stop players escaping through a gate by tagging them.
- When they tag their third player, they swap roles with them.



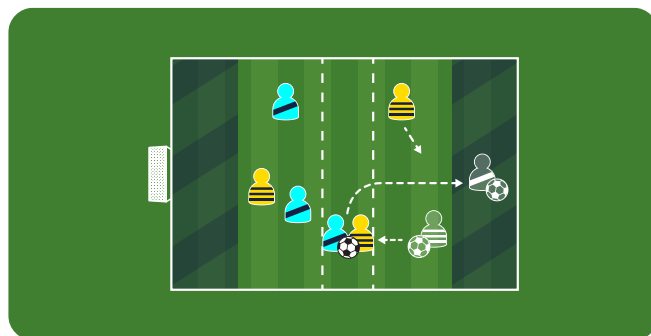
Arrival activity – continued

- Attackers carry on playing if they've been tagged – unless they need to swap roles with a defender.
- Attackers score a point each time they escape through a gate without being tagged. If they do this ten times, they then become a defender.



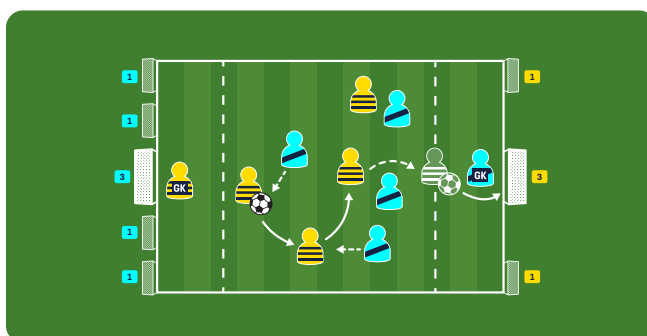
Practice one

- Create a 30x20-yard area with end zones and a middle zone. Put a goal at one end.
- Have a defender in the middle zone, two attackers in one area between zones, and two defenders and one attacker in between the other zones.
- Attackers try to play through to their teammate who then goes for goal.



Practice one – continued

- The defender in the middle zone is locked in and tries to intercept a pass or tackle an attacker that's dribbled into their zone.
- If any defender wins the ball, they break out and try to get the ball into the end zone to score.



Practice two

- Create a 30x20-yard area with end zones for this 5v5 or 6v6 'multi-goal footy' game.
- Have five goals at one end and three goals at the other.
- Teams can only have one player in their own end zone.
- Scoring in the goal that's guarded is worth three points.
- Scoring in the others is worth one point.

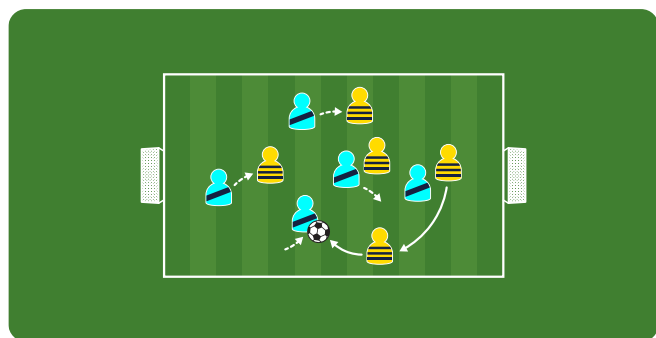
Week six: festival week

This session will help players:

- become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- communicate with teammates
- work on their positioning skills.

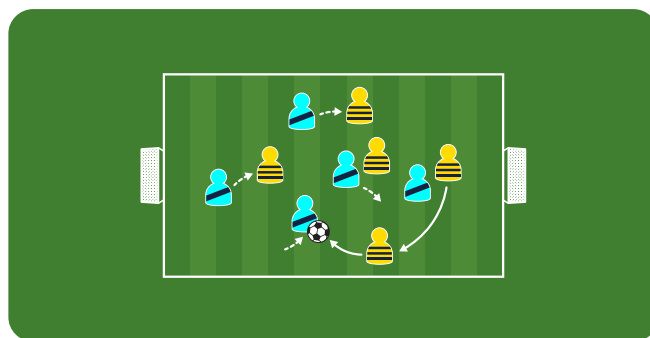
Coaching points

- Emphasise the importance of communicating with teammates. Players need to work together to take up the right positions. This will increase the chances of intercepting and help dictate where attackers can go.
- Encourage players to mark opponents closely to give themselves the opportunity to nick the ball if it is played to them.



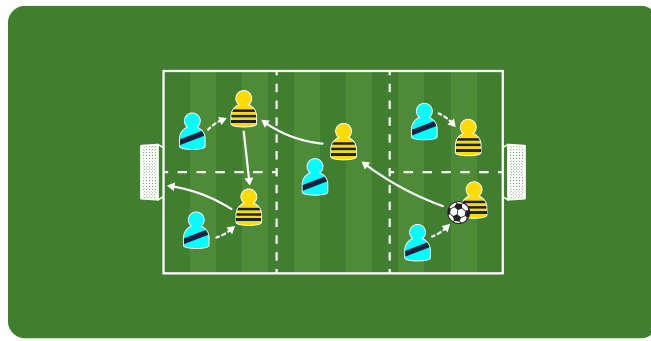
Practice one

- Create a 30x20-yard area with end zones for this 5v5 'multi-goal footy' game.
- Have five goals at one end and three goals at the other.
- Teams can only have one player in their own end zone.
- Scoring in the goal that's guarded is worth three points.
- Scoring in the others is worth one point.



Practice two

- Create a 30x20-yard area for a version of 5v5 rivals.
- Each player has a direct rival to stop scoring. Players get a point each time they do that and if they score themselves.
- At the end of the match, each pair adds a goal to their team's overall tally if they've won their individual rivals match.



Practice three

- Create a 30x20-yard area with a goal at each end. Split the pitch up into five zones.
- Two teams are matched up with a direct opponent and locked into zones so there's a 1v1 in each.
- Players work with teammates to progress the ball into other zones as they try to score in the goal they're attacking.